FREE GUIDE 01 · LEADERSHIP VISIBILITY

The Update Your VP Can Act On

Turn a status update into a clear business outcome, recommendation and decision.

Your VP replies: ‘So what do you need from me?’

You may have done valuable work. But a list of completed tasks makes the reader do the work of finding its value. A useful update connects what changed to why it matters and what should happen next.

Start here

Take the last update you sent. Underline the sentence that says what changed for the business or customer. If you cannot find one, that is the sentence to write first.

01 What changed?

02 Why it matters

03 What I recommend

04 What I need

Set aside 15 minutes. Work through the examples, then print page 4 for your own situation.

SEE IT IN PRACTICE

From a familiar response to a useful one.

Fictional examples for practice. Adapt the reasoning to the facts of your situation.

TECHNOLOGY

Before: We migrated 11 services and closed 42 tickets.

After: Checkout failures fell from 8% to 3% in the week after the fix. That is five fewer failed attempts per 100. Traffic mix may explain part of the change. I recommend monitoring for another week before extending the rollout. Please approve holding the next release until Friday.

Name the observed change, keep uncertainty visible, and ask for a specific decision. Do not label the change as revenue earned without evidence.

OPERATIONS

Before: We held training for all three shifts.

After: Picking errors fell from 12 to 7 per 1,000 orders during the two-week pilot on shift A. We have not tested the other shifts. I recommend extending the pilot to shift B. Can you release two trainer hours next Tuesday?

The denominator and period make the result interpretable. The next step is bounded.

COMMERCIAL

Before: We met six customers and updated the sales deck.

After: Four of six renewal conversations raised onboarding delays. I recommend testing a named onboarding owner on the next three renewals. This is a small sample, not proof of a market-wide issue. Can Sales and Operations agree an owner by Thursday?

A qualitative signal is useful when you explain its limits. You do not need to manufacture a metric.

THE METHOD

Write for the next decision.

1. Lead with the change

Say what is different for the customer, cost, risk, time or capacity. If the outcome is not known, say what you learned or what remains blocked.

2. Show enough evidence

Include a period, a comparison and a source. Separate observed change from your explanation of what caused it. Use plain language.

3. Make a recommendation

Propose one next step. Say what it would protect or improve, and what it would delay, cost or put at risk.

4. Make the request explicit

Name the decision, owner and deadline. If no decision is needed, say ‘For awareness; next review Friday.’ Do not create an approval request for work you already own.

Keep this to hand

Since [date], [outcome] changed from [baseline] to [current state]. This matters because [business effect]. We still need to check [uncertainty]. I recommend [action]. I need [decision or support] from [person] by [date].

YOUR PRINTABLE WORKSHEET

Rewrite one real update.

Use a recent piece of work. Keep customer names, internal figures and confidential details on your own copy.

01 My original update

02 What changed, for whom, and over what period?

03 What evidence supports it? What remains uncertain?

04 What do I recommend, and what is the trade-off?

05 What do I need, from whom and by when?

06 My rewritten update in four sentences

TAKE IT INTO YOUR WEEK

One useful next move.

Before you use it

Read your completed sheet once. Check each statement below.

- [ ] The first sentence describes an outcome, learning or obstacle.
- [ ] Any number has a meaningful baseline, unit and time period.
- [ ] I have not claimed sole credit for a team outcome.
- [ ] My recommendation and request are easy to find.

Try it once

Use the rewrite in your next update. After the conversation, note the first question you were asked. Did it move to the decision, or did the reader still need to reconstruct the context? Use that question to improve the next update.

Afterward, ask yourself

What did the reader understand faster? What did I still need to explain?

See where your impact gets lost.

The Leadership Visibility Check gives you six situations to practice explaining outcomes, making the main point clear and reducing uncertainty.

Take the Visibility Check →

sayantannandi.com/tests/leadership-visibility

By Sayantan Nandi
Former IT Director, Schneider Electric · Led teams of 200+ · ISB MBA